Philosopher Saul Kripke defines in his book *Naming and Necessity — the descriptive theory of names* — as six different theses that address, and even more stress, the importance of the reference of words and phrases that we associate with particular objects, and the names given to these objects. These six theses will first be explicated to give a good understanding of the theory's structure*;* this will then be followed by multiple counter arguments for theses [3], [4], [5], and [6], presented by Kripke, to show that *the descriptive theory of names* has a few vulnerabilities in its framework.

To start, we shall address thesis [1], that highlights the fact that for each name (object) there are a plethora of properties, or ϕs, as Kripke uses, associated with it. So, what's being argued here? Well, it seems to state that when we think of a name, which we can make it easy on ourselves and refer to someone well known — say Sir Issac Newton — we think of multiple ϕs that are attached to this name: a founder of calculus; the one who discovered gravity; he who split light into color; Mr. F= ma, the list goes on and on… To sum it up here, people tend to think of these properties when thinking of the name Sir Issac Newton, so if someone spoke about one of said properties everyone would know that they are referring to Sir Issac Newton.

Kripke then focuses on this idea of *uniqueness* in thesis [2], which states that an object can be uniquely identified by a particular ϕ or some mix of ϕs. We need to have a way to think about who exactly we want to think about, if using a name, especially a common name. So Kripke argues that we think of certain properties that this particular object satisfies uniquely, and that is how you end up thinking of the right person in a pool of people that may have the same names, and maybe even a few of the same properties; it's the properties that they satisfy uniquely that are of importance here.

This leads perfectly into the *satisfaction thesis* [3], which explains how if there is exactly one thing (object) that happens to have all of the given ɸs, then it is in fact the object that the name suggests it is. For how could it not be? Let us continue with our example of Sir Issac Newton. If that is in fact the name of the object that was a founder of calculus, and that that object also discovered gravity, then said object, Sir Issac Newton, satisfies the unique description based on the given ɸs and is therefore the object that Sir Issac Newton, the name, picks it out to be.

On one side of the coin we have the *satisfaction thesis*; on the other side we have the *non-existence thesis [4].* This here, with respect to *the descriptive theory of names*, is fairly straightforward. It says that if an object isn't defined uniquely by whatever properties may be posited, then the name of this object doesn't refer to anything, and reference seems to be everything here, so if a bunch of properties are listed and nothing can be defined by them, it seems to not exist.

The last two theses are a bit more complicated, but rightfully so as they tackle more crucial concepts. Starting with thesis [5], the *a-priori thesis*, states that one shouldn't have to go out into the world to know and identify with things (objects). Instead, Kripke argues that one knows things without having to be empirical strictly because we know names of objects, and part of knowing the name means that we understand its meaning because we know the properties of the object, so we should then know what this *name* means. And we should know it without having to go confirm it. This is essentially what thesis [5] is expressing.

Kripke's last thesis [6], can be thought of as the *necessity thesis.* It states that it is a necessary truth that if some object exists, then it has most of the properties (ɸs) that we know drive us towards, or better, refer us, to the name that this object hides behind. In other words, the properties help "to fix the reference" (*55)* of the name which in turn will "give the meaning" (55) of the name.

First, let us look at a counter argument for thesis [3], the *satisfaction-thesis.* Here we are presented with the idea that an object can be given a certain name if it satisfies a certain unique description. But if that is all that is needed, then what happens if we can imagine another object having most of the properties we in fact associate with the first object? Wouldn't the second object also satisfy the unique description? But the second object has a different name. So the same set of properties can refer to two different named objects? In short, yes. And this is why thesis [3] becomes vulnerable. In the *descriptive theory of names* it states that if there is *an* object that has satisfied a certain unique description, then that object is in fact the name that the properties refer to. But now we know this isn't true because another object can also have the same properties, and we can assume it will have a different name —why else would we be referring to it as another object?

Next, we shall consider a counter argument to thesis [4], the *non-existence thesis.* This one can be a bit tricky, but Kripke says that we should "give up the idea that this is a theory of meaning" *(59)*, and instead, "make it into a theory of reference" (*59).* It seems that a reverse-engineering approach works best to understand what is being said here. Let us consider an object that has three particular properties, and these properties, remember, are what help us understand what the object is – what name the properties have been associated with. Now if we discover later on that some other object satisfies the unique description (having the same three properties) in the very same fashion as the first object, then it is safe to say that we can no longer use the given three properties to refer to the name of said first object. So then it follows that an object does not exist, not only because based on a list of given properties, there may not be an object with a name that yields satisfaction, but rather because we have discovered a new object with a different name that has the same — if not most — maybe even all of the same properties, rendering the reference and relation of the first object to the associated properties, non-existent.

Moving on, Kripke shows how thesis [5], the *a-priori thesis*, can seem to assume too much. We are forced to ask ourselves if just thinking about an object: the properties that this object satisfies uniquely, and the name given to it for its satisfaction, as concepts, is enough to say that we truly *know* this object? Kripke argues, no. It seems that we can only know something *a-priori* because we happen to know a multitude of things about how the world works. But this in itself requires a thorough understanding of the world. So then how can we have knowledge a-priori regarding an object, if it isn't enough to know the name, nor the meaning of the name? It almost seems like the only things one can know a-priori are the things that they truly can't remember where or when in time they learned them, but that they are pieces of knowledge nonetheless that seem generally accepted by most to be true (e.g. the Earth is round).

Lastly, we are left with a counter argument to thesis [6], the *necessity thesis.* Kripke argues that it is completely possible to imagine an object that has attached to it certain properties, a different path (or life if you will) for the object with different properties assigned to it. So, what Kripke is arguing, in the case of Sir Issac Newton, is that we can picture a life for Newton that doesn't involve him studying the curved slopes of objects with motion, and needing to invent a new branch of mathematics in order to make sense of them; where he never goes to sit under the tree in which the famous apple fell from. And what Kripke says, seems to be true. We can all think of our own version of what Newton's life could have been. So this shows that it isn't a "necessary truth" (55) that if an object exists, then it probably has most of the properties that we would think to associate with the object's name; we can just as easily think of this object having none of these properties.

Overall, Kripke's *descriptive theory of names* highlights a lot of important factors when considering the name of an object, if that object even exists, and if it does, what makes it unique as to not be confused with another object. It is also set up in such a way as to be able to form powerful counter arguments. As we have seen with theses [3], [4], [5], and [6] especially, we need to be careful when saying that an object satisfies a unique description and is given a certain name, if there happens to be another object that can easily do the same; we must consider an object becoming non-existent simply because we discovered another with the same properties; we need to be cautious with how we deem certain knowledge of object to be a-priori; and it is not necessarily true that just because an object exists, it has whatever properties, when we can just as simply imagine the object to not have these properties.